THE SAFFRON HYBRIDS

SCINDIAS



Union minister **Jyotiraditya Scindia's** aunts are ex-Rajasthan CM Vasundhra Raje and Yashodhara Raje, a minister in MP. Grandmother Vijayaraje was a BJP founding member; father Madhavrao Scindia was minister in Congress regimes. Brother-in-law Vikramaditya Singh could join the BJP and contest from J&K

PHULKIAN



Formal Punjab CM **Amarinder Singh** has merged his new party, Punjab Lok Congress, with the BJP. Wife Preneet Kaur is a sitting Congress MP from Patiala. Brother-in-law Simranjit Singh Mann is MP from Sangrur on a SAD (Amritsar) ticket. He is pushing his daughter Jai Inder Kaur for the Patiala LS seat. Jai Inder's son is married to the daughter of Pratibha Singh, the Congress MP from Mandi, Himachal Pradesh

GANDHIS



MPs Maneka Gandhi and son **Varun Gandhi** are the estranged branch of the Nehru-Gandhi family

BAHUGUNAS



Both children of late Uttar Pradesh CM H.N. Bahuguna, Vijay Bahuguna and **Rita Bahuguna Joshi,** are in the BJP. Vijay's son Saurabh Bahuguna is a minister in Uttarakhand and Joshi is an MP from Allahabad. Ex-Uttarakhand CM B.C. Khanduri is also a cousin of Vijay Bahuguna



THE NTR CONNECTION

BJP general secretary **D. Purandeswari Devi** is the daughter of ex-Andhra Pradesh CM, the late N.T. Rama Rao, and sister-in-law of TDP chief N. Chandrababu Naidu



BOMMAIS

Karnataka CM **Basavaraj Bommai** is the son of former Janata Party chief minister, the late S.R. Bommai. His son Bharath Bommai is also active in the BJP



REDDYS

BJP vice-president **D.K. Aruna** from Telangana, a minister in united Andhra Pradesh, has political connections both on her parents' side and her in-laws. Her late father Chittem Narsi Reddy and her brothers were in the Congress

Congress leader and seven-time Shirdi MLA Radhakrishna Vikhe-Patil joined the BJP in 2019 after the party ensured the victory of his son Sujay Vikhe-Patil in the Lok Sabha election from Ahmednagar. Radhakrishna's father Balasaheb Vikhe-Patil was a Union minister in the Vajpayee government. But this state, too, has homegrown saffron dynasts: Poonam Mahajan (Mumbai North-Central MP), Pankaja Munde (BJP national secretary) and Pritam Munde (Beed MP), daughters of the late BJP stalwarts Pramod Mahajan and his brother-in-law, ex-deputy CM Gopinath Munde.

The story continues in UP, with far too many names to mention. Topping the list would have to be the Bahugunas, who even span two states (UP and Uttarakhand), Naresh Agarwal and his son Nitin and, of course, Pankaj Singh, son of defence minister Rajnath Singh.

The situation isn't too different in Karnataka, the BJP's sole bastion in the south. Starting from the family of ex-CM B.S. Yediyurappa (BSY), there are several examples. Current chief minister Basavaraj Bommai, son of the late Janata Party CM S.R. Bommai, may protest that he came into the BJP on his own steam in 2008, but then he's also promoting his son Bharath now.

THE PILOT TEST FLOPS

What happens when you entirely disregard the curious place dynasts seem to have in popular sentiments? In October 2021, bypolls were held for 29 assembly constituencies across 13 states plus Dadra and Nagar Haveli. The BJP leadership decided to try out the 'no dynasts' rule as a strict experiment and refused tickets to family members of many leaders. When the election results came out, it shocked the party—the BJP's official candidates lost miserably in these seats.

At the time, party chief J.P. Nadda was expounding on how the party was "cautiously and consciously outlawing tickets" to kith and kin. Dynasts, the BJP was insisting, were now the exception. They talked of tightening the norms, bringing in rules like allowing just one seat per family. The October 2021 bypoll defeats came as a harsh reality check, so this year has seen the party often do a U-turn, the latest example being the bypoll candidates. Still, there are shades of exceptions. On October 25, the party withdrew the candidature of Maheshwar Singh from Kullu, HP, in a punitive action after the erstwhile royal failed to dissuade his son Hiteshwar Singh from entering the fray as an Independent from neighbouring Banjar. But it also fielded minister and seven-time MLA Mahendra Thakur's son Rajat Thakur from his traditional seat, Solan (incidentally prompting a rebellion from daughter Vandana Guleria).

NEW FRONTIERS

Contrariwise, and perhaps embarrassingly, relaxing the norm is actually paying dividends. The BJP's unrelenting quest to annex new territory is one instance where this comes into play—the party has found it prudent to accommodate and even promote newbie dynasts. As Nadda himself admits, "The party is in expansion mode...we are encouraging defections or relying on the strengths of certain party leaders to enter new territories." This strategy is working in the